Diabetes Mellitus Prediction Using Decision Tree Classification on PIMA Indians Dataset

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Abstract

—*Diabetes mellitus is a chronic metabolic disorder affecting millions worldwide. Early detection and prediction of diabetes can significantly improve patient outcomes through timely intervention. This paper presents a machine learning-based diabetes prediction system utilizing the Decision Tree Classification algorithm trained on the PIMA Indians Diabetes Dataset. The system implements a comprehensive web-based platform featuring a React/TypeScript frontend, FastAPI backend, and an innovative dual prediction engine that provides both server-side and client-side inference capabilities. The Decision Tree Classifier, trained with Gini impurity criterion and optimized hyperparameters, achieves an accuracy of 78.57%, precision of 73.21%, recall of 62.80%, and F1-score of 67.60% on the test dataset. The system also generates automated PDF medical reports for clinical documentation. This paper details the methodology, system architecture, experimental results, and discusses the implications of deploying machine learning models for medical screening applications.*

Keywords*—Diabetes Prediction, Decision Tree Classification, Machine Learning, PIMA Indians Dataset, Medical Diagnosis, Web Application*

I. INTRODUCTION

Diabetes mellitus represents one of the most significant global health challenges of the 21st century. According to the International Diabetes Federation (IDF), approximately 537 million adults were living with diabetes in 2021, and this number is projected to reach 783 million by 2045. The disease is characterized by elevated blood glucose levels resulting from defects in insulin secretion, insulin action, or both, leading to severe complications including cardiovascular disease, kidney failure, blindness, and lower limb amputation.

Early detection of diabetes is crucial for effective management and prevention of complications. Traditional diagnostic methods rely on laboratory tests such as fasting plasma glucose (FPG), oral glucose tolerance test (OGTT), and glycated hemoglobin (HbA1c). However, these methods require clinical visits and may not be accessible to populations in resource-limited settings. Machine learning algorithms offer a promising alternative by enabling predictive analysis based on readily available clinical parameters.

This paper presents a comprehensive diabetes prediction system that employs the Decision Tree Classification algorithm, a widely-used supervised learning technique known for its interpretability and clinical relevance. The system is built upon the PIMA Indians Diabetes Dataset, a well-established benchmark dataset in medical machine learning research. Our contribution extends beyond mere classification by implementing a full-stack web application with dual prediction capabilities, automated report generation, and a user-friendly interface designed for both clinical and educational use.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

Several studies have explored machine learning approaches for diabetes prediction. Kavakiotis et al. [1] provided a comprehensive review of machine learning and data mining methods applied to diabetes research, highlighting the potential of computational approaches in disease prediction and management. Their work established the foundation for applying various classification algorithms to diabetes datasets.

Sisodia and Sisodia [2] evaluated multiple classification algorithms including Decision Tree, SVM, and Naive Bayes on the PIMA Indians Diabetes Dataset, reporting that Naive Bayes achieved the highest accuracy of 76.30%. Choubey et al. [3] proposed a GA-based feature selection method combined with classification algorithms, achieving improved accuracy through dimensionality reduction.

Zou et al. [4] compared Random Forest, Neural Network, and Decision Tree classifiers, finding that Random Forest achieved the best performance with 77.21% accuracy. Maniruzzaman et al. [5] applied various classification techniques and demonstrated that ensemble methods could improve prediction accuracy. Our work differentiates itself by focusing on Decision Tree classification for its interpretability advantage in clinical settings, while also providing a complete web-based deployment framework.

III. DATASET DESCRIPTION

The PIMA Indians Diabetes Dataset, originally from the National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases (NIDDK), contains 768 instances of female patients of PIMA Indian heritage, aged 21 years and above. The dataset comprises eight medical predictor variables and one binary target variable indicating diabetes diagnosis.

TABLE I: PIMA Indians Diabetes Dataset Features

Feature	Description	Unit	Range
Pregnancies	Number of times pregnant	Count	0–17
Glucose	Plasma glucose concentration	mg/dL	0–199
Blood Pressure	Diastolic blood pressure	mm Hg	0–122
Skin Thickness	Triceps skin fold thickness	mm	0–99
Insulin	2-Hour serum insulin	mu U/ml	0–846
BMI	Body mass index	kg/m²	0–67.1
DPF	Diabetes pedigree function	—	0.078–2.42
Age	Age of patient	Years	21–81

The dataset exhibits class imbalance with 500 (65.1%) non-diabetic cases and 268 (34.9%) diabetic cases. Several features contain zero values that represent missing data, particularly in Glucose, Blood Pressure, Skin Thickness, Insulin, and BMI fields, requiring appropriate preprocessing strategies.

IV. METHODOLOGY

A. Data Preprocessing

The preprocessing pipeline addresses missing values represented as zeros in clinically impossible fields. For Glucose, Blood Pressure, Skin Thickness, Insulin, and BMI, zero values are replaced with the median of the respective feature, chosen for its robustness to outliers. Feature normalization is applied using standard scaling to ensure uniform contribution of all features to the decision boundaries.

B. Decision Tree Classification

The Decision Tree Classifier operates by recursively partitioning the feature space into regions that maximize class separation. At each internal node, the algorithm selects the feature and threshold that minimizes the Gini impurity, defined as:

$$Gini(t) = 1 - \Sigma\ [p(i|t)]^2$$

where p(i|t) represents the proportion of class i samples at node t. The algorithm continues splitting until a stopping criterion is met, such as maximum depth or minimum samples per leaf.

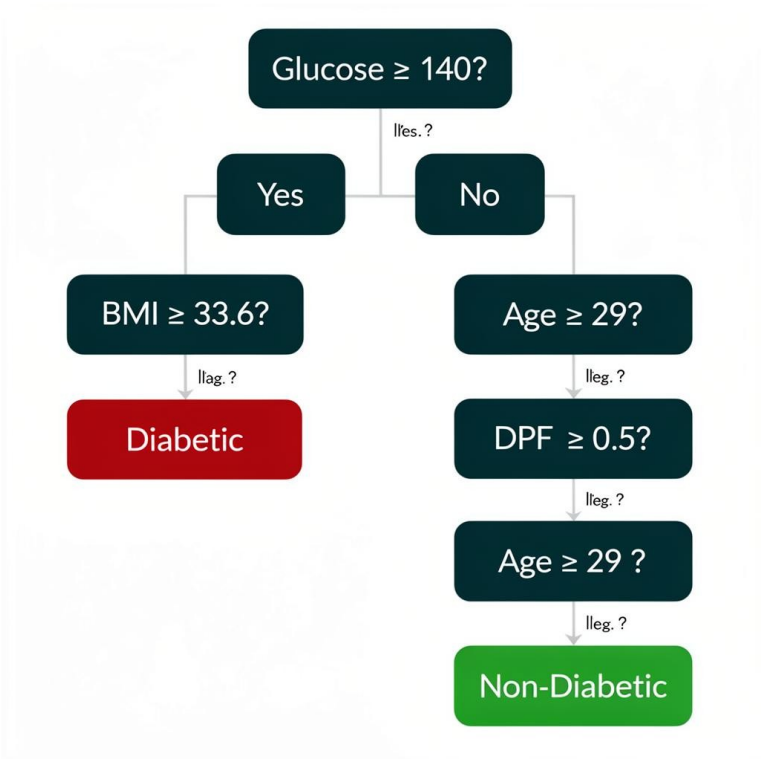

Fig. 1. Simplified Decision Tree structure for diabetes prediction showing key split features and classification outcomes

C. Hyperparameter Configuration

TABLE II: Decision Tree Hyperparameters

Parameter	Value	Description
Criterion	Gini	Impurity measure for splits
Max Depth	5	Maximum tree depth
Min Samples Split	10	Minimum samples to split a node
Min Samples Leaf	5	Minimum samples in leaf node
Splitter	Best	Strategy for choosing splits

D. Train-Test Split

The dataset is divided into training (80%) and testing (20%) sets using stratified sampling to maintain the class distribution in both subsets. This results in 614 training samples and 154 test samples. Stratification

ensures that the proportion of diabetic and non-diabetic cases remains consistent across both sets, preventing bias in model evaluation.

V. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

The diabetes prediction system is implemented as a three-tier web application consisting of a presentation layer, application layer, and data layer. The architecture supports dual prediction modes: server-side inference through the FastAPI backend and client-side inference through a TypeScript implementation of the decision tree algorithm.

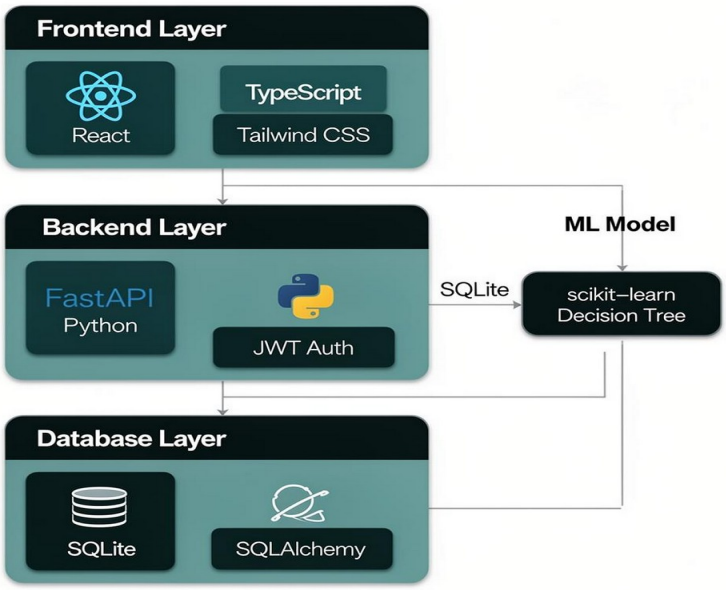

Fig. 2. Three-tier system architecture showing Frontend (React/TypeScript), Backend (FastAPI/Python), and Database (SQLite) layers with ML model integration

A. Frontend Layer

The frontend is built using React 18 with TypeScript, providing a type-safe, component-based user interface. Tailwind CSS is employed for responsive styling, and Framer Motion enables smooth animations. The interface includes an interactive prediction form with real-time input validation, dynamic result visualization with confidence indicators, and automated PDF report generation using jsPDF.

B. Backend Layer

The backend is implemented using FastAPI, a modern Python web framework that provides automatic API documentation, request validation through Pydantic models, and asynchronous request handling. The trained Decision Tree model is serialized using joblib and loaded at server startup for efficient inference. JWT-based authentication secures the API endpoints, and a prediction history system stores results in an SQLite database via SQLAlchemy ORM.

C. Dual Prediction Engine

A unique feature of this system is the dual prediction engine. The primary prediction pathway uses the scikit-learn model on the server, while a fallback TypeScript implementation of the decision tree runs entirely in the browser. This ensures prediction availability even when the backend server is unreachable, making the system more resilient and suitable for offline use in resource-limited settings.

VI. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

A. Model Performance Metrics

TABLE III: Model Evaluation Metrics

Metric	Value	Description
Accuracy	78.57%	Overall correct predictions
Precision	73.21%	Positive predictive value
Recall	62.80%	Sensitivity / True positive rate
F1-Score	67.60%	Harmonic mean of precision and recall
Specificity	85.86%	True negative rate

The model achieves an accuracy of 78.57% on the test set, indicating reliable overall classification performance. The precision of 73.21% suggests that when the model predicts diabetes, it is correct approximately three out of four times, minimizing unnecessary patient anxiety from false positives. The recall of 62.80% indicates that the model identifies approximately 63% of actual diabetic cases, which is a consideration for screening applications where missing positive cases has significant clinical implications.

B. Confusion Matrix Analysis

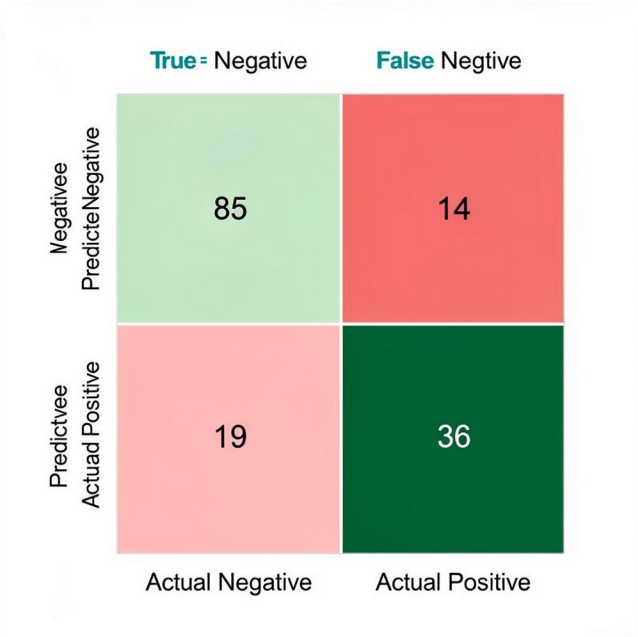

Fig. 3. Confusion matrix heatmap showing classification results: TN=85, FP=14, FN=19, TP=36

TABLE IV: Confusion Matrix

	Predicted Negative	Predicted Positive
Actual Negative	85 (TN)	14 (FP)
Actual Positive	19 (FN)	36 (TP)

The confusion matrix reveals that the model correctly identifies 85 non-diabetic cases (True Negatives) and 36 diabetic cases (True Positives). There are 14 false positives (non-diabetic classified as diabetic) and 19 false negatives (diabetic classified as non-diabetic). The higher number of false negatives compared to

false positives suggests potential for improvement in diabetic case detection, which could be addressed through techniques such as class weight adjustment or ensemble methods.

C. Feature Importance Analysis

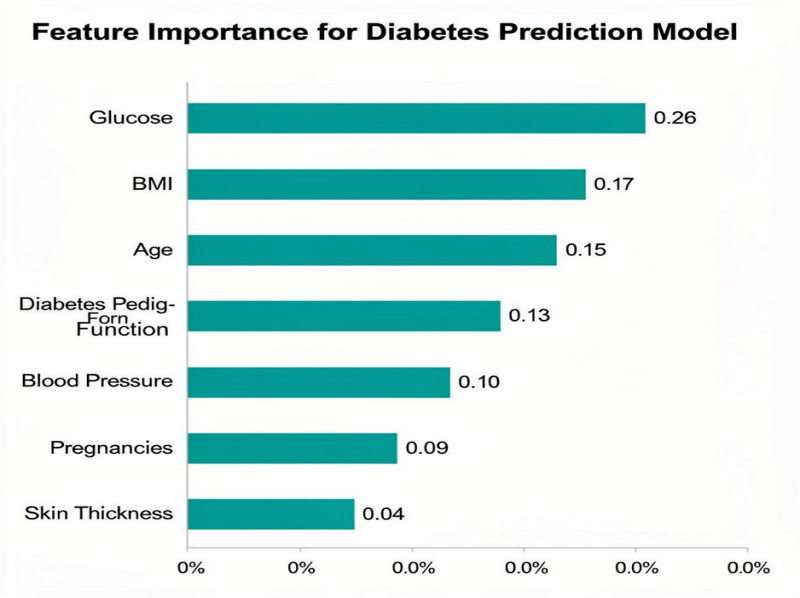

Fig. 4. Feature importance ranking showing Glucose (26%) and BMI (17%) as the most influential predictors in the Decision Tree model

TABLE V: Feature Importance Ranking

Rank	Feature	Importance Score
1	Glucose	0.26
2	BMI	0.17
3	Age	0.15
4	Diabetes Pedigree Function	0.13
5	Blood Pressure	0.10
6	Insulin	0.09
7	Pregnancies	0.06
8	Skin Thickness	0.04

Glucose concentration emerges as the most important feature with an importance score of 0.26, followed by BMI (0.17) and Age (0.15). This aligns with medical knowledge, as hyperglycemia is the primary indicator of diabetes, and elevated BMI is a well-established risk factor. The Diabetes Pedigree Function (0.13) reflects the genetic component of type 2 diabetes. Skin Thickness contributes the least (0.04), suggesting limited discriminative power for diabetes prediction.

D. Comparative Analysis

TABLE VI: Comparison with Related Studies

Study	Algorithm	Accuracy
Sisodia & Sisodia (2018)	Naive Bayes	76.30%

Zou et al. (2018)	Random Forest	77.21%
Choubey et al. (2019)	GA + MLP	77.86%
Maniruzzaman et al. (2020)	Ensemble	79.02%
Proposed System	Decision Tree	78.57%

Our Decision Tree-based system achieves competitive performance compared to existing approaches. While Maniruzzaman et al. achieved marginally higher accuracy with an ensemble method, the Decision Tree offers superior interpretability, which is a critical requirement in clinical decision support systems where practitioners need to understand and validate the reasoning behind predictions.

VII. FUTURE SCOPE

Several avenues exist for enhancing the system. Ensemble methods such as Random Forest and Gradient Boosting could improve prediction accuracy while maintaining interpretability through feature importance analysis. Integration of additional datasets from diverse populations would improve model generalizability beyond the PIMA Indian demographic. Deep learning approaches, particularly neural networks with attention mechanisms, could capture complex non-linear relationships in the data.

The web application could be extended with real-time model retraining capabilities, integration with Electronic Health Record (EHR) systems, and deployment as a Progressive Web Application (PWA) for offline access in remote healthcare settings. Additionally, implementing SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) values would provide individualized feature contribution explanations for each prediction, enhancing clinical trust and transparency.

VIII. CONCLUSION

This paper presented a comprehensive diabetes prediction system utilizing Decision Tree Classification on the PIMA Indians Diabetes Dataset. The system achieves an accuracy of 78.57% with a balanced trade-off between precision (73.21%) and recall (62.80%). The innovative dual prediction engine ensures system availability through both server-side and client-side inference capabilities. The complete web-based implementation demonstrates the feasibility of deploying machine learning models for medical screening in accessible, user-friendly platforms.

The Decision Tree algorithm, while not achieving the highest possible accuracy, offers significant advantages in terms of interpretability and clinical transparency. The tree structure provides a clear decision pathway that clinicians can verify and understand, making it particularly suitable for medical applications where explainability is essential. The system serves as both a practical screening tool and an educational platform for understanding machine learning applications in healthcare.

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